

Toward a Fuller Public Baseline for Commercial Vacancy and Lease Cost in NYC

Not instead of storefront data — alongside it

Plain ask: Please help scope a **privacy-preserving pilot open-data release** of geography-aggregated commercial vacancy and lease-cost indicators derived from Department of Finance **Real Property Income and Expense (RPIE)** filings — ideally by census tract where publishable, with Council District, borough, and citywide rollups — plus a short methods note and a coverage/suppression table.

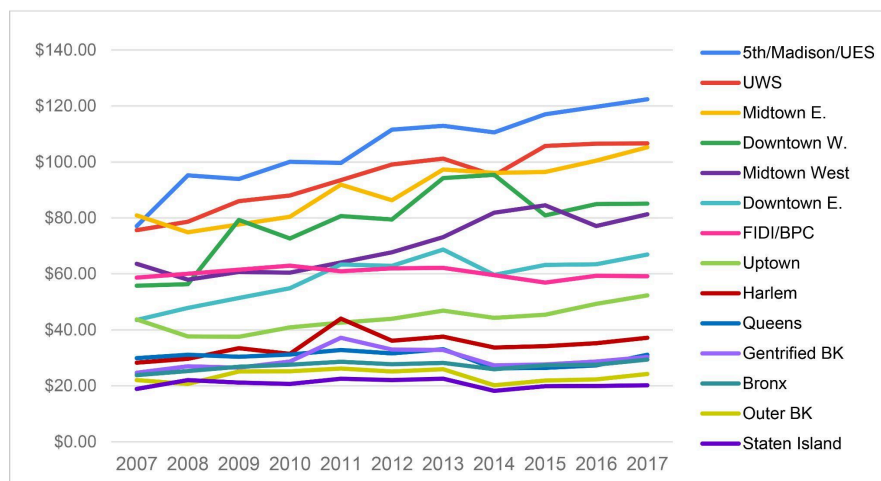
New York City already has an important public storefront reporting system, including the “**Storefronts Reported Vacant or Not**” dataset and related storefront statistics and Council analysis. That work should be **maintained and improved**. It makes visible one valuable slice of neighborhood commercial life: reported storefront units, especially on the ground and second floors.

This proposal asks for a **complementary** public lens, not a replacement.

Two public lenses can do different jobs

- **Existing storefront reporting** helps show visible storefront units, vacancy status, and storefront-level conditions.
- **RPIE aggregate indicators** can help show commercial vacancy and lease conditions across a broader square-foot universe.
- **Together** they can provide a **fuller public baseline** for vacancy, occupancy, and affordability.

Why add the RPIE lens?



Source: RPIE Filings 2007 to 2017. Average rents are equal total annual retail rental income divided by total occupied retail square feet. Rents in nominal dollars.

- **Longer history:** RPIE can help extend the time series to years before the storefront registry existed.
- **Broader coverage:** It can include commercial space above the first two floors, not only storefront units.
- **Different denominator:** It measures vacancy and occupancy as a share of **total available square footage**, which complements storefront counts. This matters because the same architectural space may be subdivided, merged, or reconfigured over time.
- **Rent and vacancy together:** It can help show lease cost and occupancy conditions within the same administrative universe.
- **Cross-validation:** Because RPIE is collected in the context of tax filings, aggregated indicators can help compare patterns across datasets and improve confidence in public analysis.
- **Public precedent:** Related RPIE-derived indicators already appear in public city reports. Publishing them in machine-readable aggregate form would build on an existing public use case.



The smallest serious pilot

A practical first release could have three parts:

1. **Commercial lease and vacancy indicators table**
Annual, geography-aggregated indicators for **all_commercial**, and **retail** if feasible.
2. **Coverage / suppression table**
Contributing counts, missingness, suppression rules, and dominance checks.
3. **Methods note**
Plain-language definitions, filing-year logic, geography-allocation rules, and caveats.

Minimum useful fields

- year
- geography
- contributing count
- occupied rentable square feet
- vacant rentable square feet, or vacancy share within the included universe
- weighted mean and p25 / p50 / p75 gross rent per square foot
- suppression flag
- release version / freeze date

What this is not

This is **not** a request for raw confidential filings, tenant names, EIN / SSN, parcel-level rent rows, unit-level lease records, or uploaded lease documents.

It is a request for a **privacy-preserving, reusable public indicator layer**.

Why this matters

A modest pilot would support:

- neighborhood analysis
- small-business affordability research
- Council oversight
- public understanding
- future policy design

A separate comparison between storefront vacancy data and HUD-USPS business vacancy data could follow as a validation lane. But the main ask here is the **RPIE aggregate pilot**.

Most helpful next step

I would especially welcome help identifying:

1. the right data owner and publication path
2. the most realistic first geography
3. the smallest publishable v1
4. whether the next step is a formal public request, an agency conversation, a short pilot working session, or some combination

I'm sharing this at School of Data because this question sits at the intersection of open-data practice, public-interest analysis, and policy design.

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